

Best Low-Impact Exercises for Gout in the Feet

Practical NHS-backed advice on best low impact exercises for gout in feet.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Best Low-Impact Exercises for Gout in the Feet

Quick Answer: The best low-impact exercises for gout in the feet are swimming, cycling, seated exercises, ankle circles, and gentle walking on flat ground. These maintain joint mobility without loading painful toe or ankle joints. Avoid all exercise during an active gout flare — wait until the acute attack fully resolves.

Exercise is important for people with gout — it helps maintain weight, supports cardiovascular health, and reduces joint stiffness long-term. The challenge is choosing exercises that don't aggravate sensitive foot joints.

During a Gout Attack: Rest the Joint

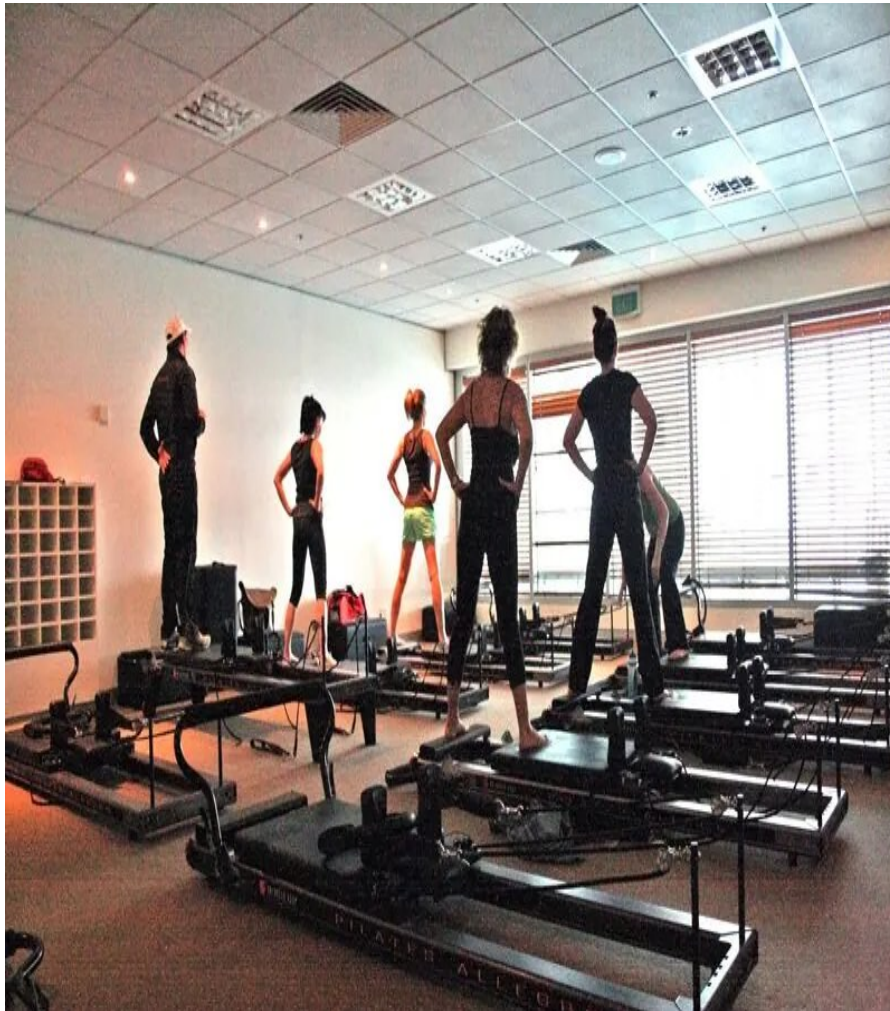
During an acute flare — intense pain, redness, warmth, and swelling in the big toe or ankle — complete rest is essential. Elevate the foot, apply ice wrapped in a cloth for 20 minutes at a time, and take prescribed medication. Do not exercise until the acute phase fully resolves (usually 3–10 days).

Best Exercises Between Gout Attacks

- **Swimming:** Zero impact on foot joints, excellent cardiovascular exercise
- **Cycling:** Stationary or road bike avoids foot-strike impact
- **Seated exercises:** Ankle circles, heel raises, toe spreads — build foot strength
- **Water aerobics:** Buoyancy reduces joint load significantly

- Walking: Gentle flat-surface walking is fine between attacks with good footwear
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Footwear Matters



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Wide-fitting trainers with good cushioning and a broad toe box are essential. Tight or narrow shoes worsen forefoot pain and can trigger flares. Specialist footwear shops can assess your feet and recommend appropriate styles.

Q&A;

Question: Is walking OK during a gout flare? **Short answer:** No — walking loads the affected joints and can prolong the flare. Rest the foot completely during an acute attack.

Question: Can exercise reduce gout attacks long-term? **Short answer:** Yes — regular moderate exercise helps maintain healthy weight and may improve uric acid clearance. Combined with dietary changes and medication, exercise is an important part of long-term gout management.

Question: How soon after a gout flare can I return to exercise? **Short answer:** Wait until all pain, swelling, and redness have fully resolved — typically 3–10 days for an acute attack. Then start gently with seated exercises before progressing to walking.

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